The Nilgiris and the Hill Stations of Tamil Nadu

Introduction to the Nilgiris

The Nilgiris, which means "blue mountains" in Tamil and Sanskrit, are a range of mountains in the Western Ghats in the north-west of Tamil Nadu, where they meet the borders of Kerala and Karnataka. They get the name from the bluish haze caused by the Neelakurinji flowers that bloom on the slopes once every 12 years, and the blue-tinged mist. The Nilgiris district, with its headquarters at Udhagamandalam, usually called Ooty, has an average altitude of about 2,000 metres. The highest peak is Doddabetta, at about 2,637 metres, which is also the highest point in the Nilgiris and the tallest in Tamil Nadu. The area is a part of the Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve, which was established in 1986 as India's first biosphere reserve, and which is known for its rare plants and animals, including the Nilgiri tahr, the lion-tailed macaque and the Bengal tiger. The Nilgiris are home to indigenous tribal groups such as the Todas, Kotas, Irulas, Kurumbas and Badagas.

Name Three Hill Stations in Tamil Nadu

Three well-known hill stations of Tamil Nadu are Udhagamandalam (Ooty), Kodaikanal and Coonoor. Udhagamandalam, in the Nilgiris, called the "Queen of Hill Stations", lies at about 2,240 metres. It was developed by the British, starting with John Sullivan, Collector of Coimbatore, who built the first house there in 1819, and it became the summer capital of the Madras Presidency. Ooty is famous for the Government Botanical Garden, established in 1848, the Ooty Lake, Doddabetta peak, the Rose Garden and the Government Rose Garden with thousands of varieties of roses, the Ooty flower show held every May, and the old British buildings. Kodaikanal, in the Palani Hills of Dindigul district, is called the "Princess of Hill Stations", at about 2,100 metres, and is known for its star-shaped Kodai Lake, Coaker's Walk, Pillar Rocks, Bryant Park, the Kurinji Andavar Temple and the Neelakurinji flower, which blooms once every 12 years, with the last mass bloom in 2018 and the next expected in 2030. Coonoor, also in the Nilgiris, at about 1,850 metres, has tea estates, Sim's Park, established in 1874, and Dolphin's Nose viewpoint. Other hill stations include Kotagiri, also in the Nilgiris, Yercaud in the Shevaroy Hills near Salem, known for coffee and its lake, Valparai in the Anamalai Hills, with tea estates and rich wildlife, Yelagiri, Kolli Hills, Javadi Hills and Megamalai.

What Is the Nilgiri Mountain Railway?

The Nilgiri Mountain Railway (NMR) is a heritage metre-gauge railway line that runs about 46 kilometres from Mettupalayam, at the foot of the hills, through Coonoor to Udhagamandalam (Ooty). It is the only rack railway in India. The line was first proposed in 1854 and the section from Mettupalayam to Coonoor opened in 1899, and it was extended to Ooty in 1908. It climbs from about 326 metres to about 2,203 metres above sea level over a journey of about five hours, passing through 16 tunnels, over about 250 bridges and around about 208 curves. On the steepest section between Kallar and Coonoor, which has a gradient of about 1 in 12.5, the train uses the Abt rack-and-pinion system, in which a toothed wheel under the locomotive grips a toothed rail. It is famous for its blue and cream "toy train" coaches, which are pulled by vintage steam locomotives on the rack section and diesel engines on the upper section, with the steam locomotive built in Switzerland and in India. It was declared a UNESCO World Heritage Site in July 2005 as an extension of the Mountain Railways of India, along with the Darjeeling Himalayan Railway (inscribed in 1999) and the Kalka-Shimla Railway (inscribed in 2008). The railway has appeared in many films, including the famous song "Chaiyya Chaiyya" from the Hindi film Dil Se (1998).

What Is the Nilgiris Known for Growing?

The Nilgiris are best known for tea. Tea was introduced to the Nilgiris by the British in the 19th century, with the first plantations around Coonoor and Kotagiri in the 1830s and 1840s, and today the Nilgiris is one of India's main tea-growing regions, along with Assam and Darjeeling. Nilgiri tea is known for its fragrant, brisk and flavourful taste, grown at high altitudes of 1,000 to 2,500 metres, and it has a geographical indication (GI) tag. Tamil Nadu produces a significant share of south India's tea, and tea auctions are held at Coonoor. The region also grows coffee, spices such as cardamom and pepper, and many vegetables including carrots, cabbage, beetroot, cauliflower and potatoes, which are called "English vegetables", along with fruits such as plums and pears, and eucalyptus trees, which give eucalyptus oil. Ooty is famous for its chocolates, varkey biscuits and the Nilgiri Tea. Many of the Toda tribe's embroidered shawls are also traded.

Culture and Wildlife

The Todas, a pastoral tribe, have unique barrel-shaped huts, buffalo-herding traditions and embroidered shawls called pukhoor. The Mudumalai National Park and Tiger Reserve, Mukurthi National Park, home to the Nilgiri tahr, the Avalanche area, and the Upper Bhavani lake offer nature trails. The Lawrence School in Lovedale, the Defence Services Staff College in Wellington and the Pasteur Institute at Coonoor are important institutions.

Climate and Visiting

The climate in the hills is cool throughout the year, with temperatures typically from 5 to 25 degrees Celsius, and the best time to visit is from October to June, with the monsoon bringing heavy rain. In summer, the hill stations attract many tourists from Chennai, Coimbatore and Bengaluru.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include deforestation, landslides during heavy rain, pressure on water from tourism and construction, plastic waste and human-wildlife conflict. The Madras High Court has controlled tourist vehicles and construction in the hills, and the state promotes eco-tourism and the protection of shola forests and grasslands.

Quick Facts

- Three hill stations in Tamil Nadu are Udhagamandalam (Ooty), Kodaikanal and Coonoor; others include Yercaud and Valparai.
- The Nilgiri Mountain Railway runs 46 km from Mettupalayam to Ooty and is a UNESCO World Heritage Site since 2005.
- The Nilgiris are best known for tea; Doddabetta is the highest peak.
- The Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve, established in 1986, was India's first biosphere reserve.
- Neelakurinji blooms once in 12 years, last in 2018.